

START ON SUCCESS:

A school and business collaboration
model offering work-based learning
for students with disabilities

By Kelly Ligon, Kendel St. John, Elizabeth Evans Getzel,
Susan McKelvey & Aliza Lambert



“Because I get to go to work every day, that makes me want to come to school every day.”

— A feeling expressed by a student enrolled in Virginia’s Start on Success (SOS) program

Students connect what they learn in high school to the world of work. The opportunity to work provides high school students a valuable learning experience. They find a purpose for coming to school. For students with disabilities (SWD), a college and career readiness gap exists. SWD are less likely to graduate on time, attend college, or be employed compared to those without a disability (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2021).

Work-based learning prepares SWD for college and careers.

Completion of career and technical education (CTE) courses and work-based learning (WBL) programs have been shown to close the career readiness gap. Students with disabilities involved in CTE have fewer unexcused absences, are more likely to graduate on time, and are more likely to be employed after graduation (Theobald, Goldhaber, Gratz, & Holden, 2017).

To address the need for access to CTE courses and WBL, we will provide information from seven years of operating SOS, a high-quality WBL program. SOS is built on the collaboration of special education, CTE, vocational rehabilitation (VR) and the business community. We will review essential components of SOS that benefit CTE, VR and special education. These benefits are corroborated by Perkins V, Workforce Innovation and

Opportunity Act (WIOA), and Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA), which recommend WBL experiences for all students, including those with disabilities. Demographic and outcome data on students who have completed SOS will demonstrate the impact of this program on various populations.

Why is SOS important?

School districts seek out business partners who will provide individual internship experiences for eight students. Students in the SOS program participate in an interview process with the business, which develops employability skills and identifies strengths and interests for career pathway placement. Often these experiences assist students to learn about career options they had not previously considered.

Career pathway-focused learning connects students with opportunities to earn industry credentials as they transition into successful careers and/or postsecondary education. Legislation, such as Perkins V, WIOA and IDEA, provides support for career pathways. In fact, IDEA specifically mandates that transition services be included in individualized education plans (IEPs). CTE presents a method to fulfill this mandate (Harvey, et al., 2019).

Additionally, workforce development is funded through Title I of WIOA and can be utilized to support and educate students to obtain 21st-century work skills. These legislative mandates encourage schools to utilize the wealth of resources available through CTE programs and customize WBL experiences to meet the needs of students with disabilities. Furthermore, this legislation includes youth programs to enhance workforce development and connect academics to technical and employability skills (Cushing, et al., 2019).

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What is SOS?

Virginia's Start on Success program is designed for high school seniors with disabilities who are pursuing a standard or advanced studies diploma. SWD should be provided opportunities to increase career pathway skills through WBL. To increase student success, SOS components consist of four evidence-based practices related to in-school or post-school success for students with disabilities (Test, et al., 2009). These SOS core components (Table 1) contribute to the success of the program.

SOS places great emphasis on collaboration. The program is designed to demonstrate the success of collaborative partnerships between students, families, schools, community agencies and employers in preparing students for the transition to post-school activities.

- Our local vocational rehabilitation agency offers valuable contributions to the development, implementation and evaluation of the program. VR improves outcomes and quality of life for individuals with disabilities

by providing support for obtaining and maintaining employment.

- Nurtured business partnerships benefit SOS through mentoring and job placements. Business partners provide the school and students with an industry perspective.
- Within the school district, collaboration between special education and CTE benefits both the SOS program and students. Stakeholders establish the career prism with which to view school coursework and programming.

To assist students with learning career-readiness skills, the model requires students to participate in a credit-bearing CTE course during the first semester of the SOS program. This course teaches students to make informed career and continuing education choices as they transition from school, gain technical skills and adapt to the workplace.

The curriculum includes:

- Ethical behaviors
- Career research

(1) Interagency Collaboration: Special education teachers, CTE personnel, school administrators, vocational rehabilitation and other community agencies comprise the SOS planning team.

(2) CTE Course: Career and technical education provides opportunities for job exploration, postsecondary education counseling, workplace readiness training and self-advocacy.

(3) Paid Internship: Completed in a community business, including opportunities for students to reflect on work performance, students set goals and relate their internship experiences to their education.

(4) Mentorship: Students pair with business mentors to network, gain references and work experiences, and increase disability acceptance.

Table 1 Core Components of Start on Success

- Self-awareness
- Self-advocacy
- Customer service
- Life skills

In addition to the CTE curriculum, the SOS model encourages school districts to supplement with additional instruction and activities related to career pathways. Students may also earn a CTE credential if they meet the course competencies, which may further their opportunities for long-term meaningful employment. Too often students miss the connection between school and career. However, through their CTE coursework, students cultivate a positive view of their education on career prospects.

Since piloting SOS in 2014, Virginia has successfully implemented this model in urban, rural and suburban communities. It works within the school setting to teach vital career and employment skills. The program also fits within the community by supporting students in local businesses as they transfer skills to the workplace.

Generalize classroom instruction with hands-on work experience.

Via WBL, students develop employability skills in a structured environment. SOS incorporates a paid internship at a business within the community. Students receive support on the job site from business mentors as well as from a school staff member on site to assist with problem-solving, accommodations and applying career pathways skills.

While work hours vary by the school district and business partnership, most students work approximately 15 hours per week for 16 weeks. Some districts schedule the internship during the school day, whereas others extend beyond school hours. In the SOS model, students are paid at or above minimum wage. The responsibility for paying the wages can be nego-

tiated among key stakeholders including schools, community agencies (e.g., VR) and the host business.

To ensure the student receives adequate feedback, both the business and job coaches synthesize data on work behaviors. A mentor then discusses areas of strength and needed improvement with the student.

Find a business partner that is fully engaged and committed.

After identifying a local business, approach each department within the company and seek out employees interested in volunteering. SOS business mentors provide training, support and encouragement to students as they acclimate to the business culture. Students are paired with business mentors to network within the community, gain references and work experience, and increase disability acceptance.

Business mentors assist with training, identify a work routine, set high expectations and promote independence. They work collaboratively with all stakeholders to assess and communicate feedback on student performance.

Students gain vital work skills in authentic business environments while the business partners influence the next wave of potential employees. Data collected from SOS sites indicates positive program outcomes. And, anecdotally, schools report host businesses hiring students to work in permanent employment following internships.

Outcomes

We have been collecting outcome data on participating students since the implementation of SOS in Virginia in 2014. Data are collected at graduation, and at six- and 12-months post-graduation. At graduation, the school systems provide information on what students' plans are immediately after graduation. At the six- and 12-month data collection points, the school systems give current information

on former SOS students, such as what they have been doing since graduation where they work or go to school, and, if working, their hourly wage.

76% of students who participated in SOS from 2014–19 graduated on time and, within one year of graduation, entered either postsecondary education, employment (or both), or enlisted in the military.

A majority of those students entered employment or postsecondary education. Of the school systems who disclosed participant race/ethnicity, 70% of participants were students of color, and 20% were white.

Conclusion

As a result of seven years of working with school districts in Virginia, we have found it to be effective for SWD in secondary education to be involved in CTE programs. The model incorporates all the essential components for student success, including a CTE course, paid internship, involvement of community agencies and the business community. SOS provides a framework that meets high-quality CTE practices and offers opportunities for students with disabilities, representing diverse populations, to succeed in building their careers. ■

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Kelly Ligon, M.Ed., is research and demonstration associate for the Center on Transition Innovations at Virginia Commonwealth University. Since 2014, she has had primary responsibility for designing and implementing the Start on Success model in Virginia and providing training and technical assistance to ensure program sustainability and expansion of SOS within school districts across the state. Email her at kligon@vcu.edu.

Kendel St. John, M.Ed., is a transition training associate for the Center on Transition Innovations at Virginia Commonwealth University. Since 2014, she has worked with school districts to increase employment capacity for students with disabilities through work-based opportunities, such as Start on Success and Discovering ME, a person-centered process. Email her at kstjohn@vcu.edu.

Elizabeth Evans Getzel, M.A., is the director of the Rehabilitation Research and Training Center (RRTC) on employment for transition-age youth with disabilities. She has been on the VCU faculty for over 30 years and has extensive experience directing research and demonstration projects on the transition of youth with disabilities to college or employment. She has published widely on transition, career development, college and employment for youth with disabilities. Email her at lgetzel@vcu.edu.

Susan McKelvey, Ph.D., is the director of research and evaluation for Virginia Commonwealth University's Transition RRTC. She conducts data collection and analysis for the programs at both the Transition RRTC and the Center on Transition Innovations. Email her at mckelveysp@vcu.edu.

Aliza Lambert, M.Ed., C.R.C., is a career support specialist for the Center on Transition Innovations at Virginia Commonwealth University. Since 2017, she has primarily worked on developing paid employment opportunities for students in the ACE-IT in College program as well as with various school district through SOS and Discovering ME. Email her at ahweiss@vcu.edu.

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EXPLORE MORE

Start on Success video demonstrates the impact of the WBL program. <https://youtu.be/fxT1ZbJspfE>

View the instructional framework offered in the SOS model. <http://cteresource.org/curriculum/career-connections/Education%20for%20Employment%20I%209077-9078-9085-9084.pdf>

View the Start on Success Replication Guide, which includes information, strategies and tips for developing the SOS model. <https://centerontransition.org/documents/CTI%20Start%20on%20Success%20Guide.pdf>

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